do you think you could attract this girl?' We joked about it and left if there. As it transpired, she and her mother came to watch me run at the All-India Athletic Meet at the National Stadium the next day. When I won the race, she came up to congratulate me and generously invited my friends and me for dinner at her house. That evening my friends teased me mercilessly, saying, 'Beware, the loveliest rose has thorns that can scratch you.'

The next day we went to her palatial house for dinner and met her parents, who welcomed me warmly like a son, indicating that they had no objection to their daughter's friendship with me. They were an affluent business family and they shrewdly felt that having a famous sportsman as a son-in-law would be good publicity for their company. As our interactions increased, I began to feel very uneasy and stifled by the way her parents took command of my life and how they tried to control my every move, to the extent that whenever I returned from an overseas trip, their car would be waiting for me at Palam airport and they would whisk me off to their house. They even tried to interfere with my future, and dismissed my dreams and aspirations; instead they wanted me to focus on how my image could enhance their business.

She entered my life when I was young and impressionable, and it was clear to me, right from the start, that we could never have forged a deeper relationship. She was very beautiful and we were close friends, but I had no desire to give into her family's demands and dikats.

Gradually, I began to distance myself from the family, but they were extremely influential and threatened that if I did not marry their daughter, they would destroy my career, or even get me murdered. Their threats and warnings, however, did not frighten me. By now I had moved to Chandigarh and hoped that the matter would be forgotten.

There were times when I would miss having a soulmate in my life, but I did not want to lose focus in my quest to become the best athlete in the world.